where we must meet and demolish the enemy.' Unfortunately, no one was listening any more.

LAME DUCKS AND PAPER TIGERS

After Exercise Lal Qila, both Thimayya and Thorat came to be known as 'lame ducks'. Thimayya, by letting Nehru repeatedly have his way, was fast losing credibility with the army as well. By then, Krishna Menon was more and more dependent on the QMG, Bijji Kaul, to get things done in Army HQ and would even bypass the Chief of General Staff, Lieutenant General L. P. 'Bogey' Sen, on a regular basis.

The much-maligned Forward Policy of the Government of India, which according to many critics—including the journalist Neville Maxwell—triggered the war in 1962, officially came into being in November 1960, but its genesis probably lay in the Kongka Pass episode. Claiming that B. N. Mullik was the father of the Forward Policy, Maxwell would later say sarcastically that Mullik decided from 'gazing into his crystal ball' that India only had to push forces up to the Chinese pickets, and the latter would retreat. After 1962 most people bought these arguments for by then it was easy to blame the Nehru-Menon-Kaul troika for the fiasco. Some others argue that the Forward Policy may be Nehru's saving grace in a scenario where he had otherwise repeatedly capitulated to the Chinese. The Forward Policy may have contributed to the subsequent military debacle, which is another matter altogether, but to call it the primary reason for the 1962 clash is to buy the Chinese argument entirely.

In fact, on 13 September 1959, Prime Minister Nehru had issued this directive:

> The Aksai Chin area has to be left more or less as it is as we have no check-posts there and practically little access. Any question in relation to it can only be considered, when the time arises, in the context of the larger question of the entire border. For the present, we have to put up with the Chinese occupation of this north-eastern sector of Ladakh and their road across it.

A year later, in November 1960, he said:

> So far as Ladakh is concerned, we are to patrol as far forward as possible from our present positions towards the International Border. This will be done with a view to establishing our posts that should prevent the Chinese from advancing any further and also dominating from any posts which they may have already established in our territory. This must be done without getting into a clash with the Chinese, unless this becomes necessary in self-defence.